

American Homecoming

Americans' antipathy to the war was shown not only toward the policymakers and generals, but also toward returning servicemen and women. For some veterans, especially those who saw combat, homecoming was a difficult adjustment.

◀◀ BEFORE

The men and women who returned from Vietnam received a very different reception from that enjoyed by the veterans of World War II.

TARNISHED IMAGE

By the time the **US exited Vietnam**, the war had become extremely unpopular, and this was reflected in the public's attitude to the returning troops. Moreover, **media coverage**, including photographs such as Nick Ut's "Napalm Girl" and Ron Haeberle's shots of the My Lai massacre, had brought some of the atrocities of the war up close.

Most Vietnam veterans returned to the US to live stable, productive, and distinguished lives. Studies demonstrate that 85 percent made successful transitions to civilian life after their time in Vietnam, and 91 percent of veterans indicated that they were proud of their service. Compared to their peers who did not serve in the war, Vietnam veterans enjoy a higher annual income, and a lower percentage of them have spent time in prison. There is no difference in statistics on drug addiction or homelessness. Their record of leadership in public life is noteworthy.

Life after warfare

Some veterans did suffer greatly after returning to the US. Adjustment problems immediately on return—particularly for the 10 percent of veterans who actually engaged in combat operations—included drug and alcohol addiction, post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), inadequate medical and mental health services, and negative perceptions of Vietnam veterans, ranging from simple indifference to outright hostility.

Black Americans returned to the same discrimination that they had experienced before their departure, and a more radical Civil Rights Movement. Many Black Americans from the South had been forever changed by their war experiences, but their rural communities expected them to return quietly to the traditional racial patterns of Southern life. Some urban Black veterans found militant groups such as the Black Panthers appealing.

Unemployment was also a serious problem among Black American veterans. In 1973, unemployment for white veterans aged 20–24 was just under 6 percent, but for comparable Black veterans it was nearly 33 percent. US veterans organizations, dominated by those who served in World War II, did not welcome the new generation of veterans, and were especially resistant to Black Americans.